A couple of weeks later I received a letter from Quartermaster Kilpatrick. He thanked me for arranging the chance to speak to his wife, and went on to describe what it had been like that day in the Mediterranean. Because of the maneuvers, he said, the air had been full of radio traffic, ships talking to ships, admirals talking to admirals. Suddenly, a voice came over the air and said, “White House calling.” Another voice said, “What code is that?”

Then a third voice spoke up: “Maybe that’s no code, maybe it’s the White House calling.”

“Not even Hollywood could have silenced the airwaves as quickly as they were silenced,” young Kilpatrick wrote. “Then they came down and found a lowly quartermaster on a tin can and told him he was wanted on the phone.”

The young sailor closed his letter by saying, “It was as if God had called the Vatican and asked for an altar boy by name.” He signed his letter, “Your altar boy.”

There were more letters from him in the years that followed, always with the same sign-off. When Jack told me his son was going to reenlist and was about to be promoted, I arranged for both events to take place in the Oval Office in the presence of his family.

On the Sunday evening after I had arranged for a young wife to speak to her husband in the middle of the Mediterranean, I told Nancy, “You know, some days, this job is more fun than others.”